

Vanuatu

Ratio: 11:18 **Adopted:** February 18, 1980 **Usage:** National and Civil



Australasia and Oceania



Vanuatu, formerly known as the New Hebrides, was jointly administered by Britain and France from 1906. In 1980, it gained its independence.

During its time as an Anglo-French condominium, the New Hebrides flew the French *Tricolore* side by side with the Union Jack. After the anglophone Vanuakku Party led the country to independence as Vanuatu in 1980, the colors of the party flag—red, black, green, and yellow—were adopted as the basis for the design of a new national flag. The final design was chosen a few months before independence by a parliamentary committee from designs submitted by a local artist.

THE SYMBOLISM OF THE COLORS

The yellow symbolizes sunshine; the green, the richness of the islands. The red is symbolic of blood, and

the black is for the Melanesian people. The Prime Minister requested the inclusion of the yellow and black fimbriations to give more prominence to the color representing the people. The yellow Y-shape denotes the pattern of the islands in the Pacific Ocean.

THE BOAR'S TUSK

Between the arms of the “Y” lies the traditional emblem of a boar’s tusk—the symbol of prosperity, worn as a pendant on the islands—crossed by two leaves of the local *namele* fern. The leaves are a token of peace, and their 39 fronds represent the 39 members of Vanuatu’s legislative assembly.